

As someone who may soon be creating content on issues relating to distant suffering, how do you look upon your role -- and your capabilities -- to communicate with audiences wholeheartedly in ways that move people to act?

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In their article “Close, but not close enough?,” Huiberts and Joye explore the difficulties that audiences face when trying to connect with distant suffering. Generally speaking, it is hard for people to feel empathy for events happening in a different part of the world. Storytellers are aware of this issue and there are methods described in the article that can help combat apathy.

Stories can be approached from an emotional perspective, focus on the aid aspect, create familiarity or explain the stakes to the audience. Regardless of the method the writer chooses, the aim is essentially to elicit two emotions: empathy and sympathy. Huiberts and Joye write that creating empathy requires one to “crawl into the skin of the sufferer and feel what the sufferer feels.” Sympathy, on the other hand, is best achieved by creating understanding through a familiar setting.

During our class discussion, a more controversial method to evoke an emotional response was discussed. Using children can be highly effective for directing the eyes of the world to a particular issue. A recent example was 7-year-old Amal Hussain, whose malnourished body served as a portrait of the famine that a war-torn Yemen was experiencing¹. Her death soon after the first cover story went viral spawned some criticism. This girl had been used and exploited for clicks. As effective as children can be to grab our attention, Seu calls them the “ideal victims” in her article, audiences are often aware of this manipulation and don’t respond kindly to it.

So if children aren’t the perfect way to grab attention, what alternatives are there? I believe the question is less about finding ways to make audiences care about far away issues. Rather, we should ask ourselves if it is necessary (and if so, why?) to make readers care and act on tragic events that may or may not affect them. And this is where things become complicated because every war is unique, every famine distinct and every natural disaster unpredictable.

¹ <https://www.nytimes.com/2018/11/01/world/middleeast/yemen-starvation-amal-hussain.html>

Ultimately, what can the average reader truly contribute, even if they did care? I don't mean to belittle donations, such as those that helped Japan recover after the 2011 Tōhoku earthquake and tsunami. Rather, I am arguing that, as a journalist, our prime goal should be reporting the news objectively. We shouldn't be trying to find ways to manipulate our audiences emotionally, even if we are acting in the interest of a good cause.

I find that the world has a natural tendency to let things fall into place. If an event is worthy of our attention for humanitarian reasons, then the best thing we can do is to simply report the story to the best of our abilities. The world will listen if it needs to. Since the world is not a perfect or even fair place, this sadly means that some stories will remain untold or uncared for. And I think this is something we just have to accept. But it doesn't mean journalists should do nothing.

Steven Ward wrote about the use of emotions in reporting, and the fine line between true expression of compassion and self-promotion, particularly during a time in which news outlets are in fierce competition with each other, each vying for the audience's attention². Ward also touches on the emotional struggles that reporters face in disaster zones and the constant pressure to push out content as quickly as possible. Although journalists like to assume that their audience is simple-minded and has little time, I believe we underestimate some of our readers. Those with the capacity to care *and* act on a disaster are likely also capable of seeing through any kind of manipulation, just like respondents in Seu's article saw through the use of children for purely emotional appeals.

A workable solution would be to simply slow down coverage of disaster events. It benefits both the journalist and the reader. The journalist is given additional time to process events and produce quality content. The reader is exposed to the event for longer and won't forget the disaster as easily, another complaint that surfaced in Huiberts and Joye's research. But given the current climate and short news cycles, it seems unlikely that news outlets will move into this direction.

² <https://ethics.journalism.wisc.edu/2010/08/23/emotion-in-reporting/>